



Fundamentals of ELT/EFL

A historical account of ELT/EFL, Contexts of learning English (ESL/EFL/ESP), Learning obstacles and impediments (Language-related obstacles, content and concept simplification obstacles, learning styles-related obstacles, teacher's practice-related obstacles, classroom interaction obstacles)

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Introduction

English language teaching has evolved significantly over time, influenced by new linguistic and educational theories. Today, English is learned in different contexts such as ESL, EFL, and ESP, each with its own characteristics. However, learners often face various challenges that can affect the learning process. In this presentation, we will first examine the historical evolution of ELT/EFL, then explore the contexts of learning English, and finally discuss learner-related, instructional, and systemic obstacles that may influence English language learning.



1. Historical Evolution of ELT/EFL



Early Approaches to Language Teaching

Early language teaching methods focused mainly on learning grammar rules and translating texts rather than communicating in the language. One of the most influential methods was the Grammar–Translation Method.

This method emphasized:

 Reading classical literary texts	 Translation between the target language and the native language
 Memorization of grammar rules	 Limited focus on speaking and listening

Students often became good at analyzing grammar, but they struggled to communicate in real-life situations.

Influence of Structural Linguistics and Behaviorism

During the mid-20th century, language teaching was influenced by structural linguistics and behaviorist psychology.

Language was viewed as a system of structures, and learning a language meant mastering these structures step by step.

Behaviorism suggested that language learning occurs through:



Stimulus



Response



Reinforcement

As a result, teaching focused on habit formation.

Teaching Through Drills and Repetition

Based on behaviorist ideas, many classrooms used drills, repetition, and pattern practice.

Typical practices included:



Repeating sentences after the teacher



Practicing grammatical patterns



Memorizing dialogues

The goal was to create automatic language habits.

Although this approach helped learners improve accuracy, it often did not help them develop spontaneous communication skills.

Limitations of Form-Focused Teaching

Over time, researchers and educators noticed important limitations.

Students could:



Explain grammar rules



Complete written exercises

But they often could not communicate effectively in real situations.

This revealed a gap between **knowing the language** and **using the language**.

Emergence of Communicative Language Teaching (CLT)

In the 1970s, a new approach called Communicative Language Teaching (CLT) emerged. This approach emphasized that the main goal of language learning is communication.

CLT focuses on:



Real-life communication



Meaningful interaction



Functional use of language

Students are encouraged to use language actively, not only study its structure.

Shift from Teacher-Centered to Learner-Centered Classrooms

Modern language teaching gradually shifted from teacher-centered instruction to learner-centered learning.

In traditional classrooms:

- The teacher dominated the lesson
- Students mostly listened and repeated



In learner-centered classrooms:

- Students participate actively
- Communication and collaboration are encouraged
- Teachers act as facilitators of learning

Communicative Competence in Modern ELT

The concept of communicative competence became central to modern language teaching.

Communicative competence means the ability to:



Use grammar correctly



Use language appropriately in different social contexts



Understand and produce meaningful communication

Therefore, modern ELT focuses not only on linguistic accuracy, but also on practical communication skills.

From Language Structures to Communicative Ability

Overall, the evolution of ELT shows a major shift:

From teaching grammar and translation



To developing learners' ability to communicate effectively

Modern English teaching aims to help learners use English confidently in real-life not only understand its rules.



2. Contexts of Learning English (ESL / EFL / ESP)

The Global Spread of English

Kachru's Three Circles of English



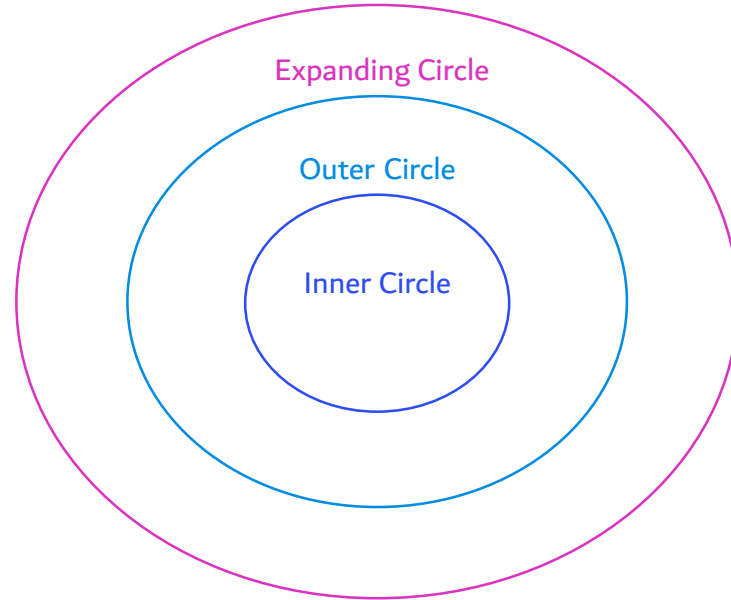
Inner Circle

Countries where English is the first language, such as the UK and the USA.



Outer Circle

Countries that were former British colonies and use English as a second language, such as India and Nigeria singapore



Expanding Circle

Countries where English is learned as a foreign language, such as China and Japan. morocco

English as a Second Language

English as a Second Language (ESL) refers to the use and study of English by non-native speakers who reside in an English-speaking country or environment where English is the dominant language of daily communication • (e.g., studying in the U.S, U.K...).

Key Characteristics of ESL:



Immersive Language Environment



Linguistic Diversity of Learners



Interlanguage Development



Focus on Communicative Competence



Linguistic heterogeneity



Integrative Motivation

English as a Foreign Language

EFL refers to the study of English by non-native speakers in countries where English is not the primary language. (e.g., learning English in Morocco, Japan, China..)

Key Characteristics of EFL:



Limited Exposure to
Authentic English Input



Instrumental Motivation



Focuses on all four language
skills with emphasis on
grammar and vocabulary



Exam-Oriented Learning



Linguistic homogeneity

English for Specific Purposes

ESP focuses on learners' specific goals and needs. It is goal-oriented, based on needs analysis, and uses language and materials adapted to learners' academic or professional contexts.

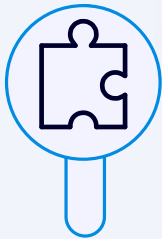
The Absolute Characteristics of ESP

According to scholars Dudley-Evans & St John and Stevens, true ESP must meet these absolute criteria:



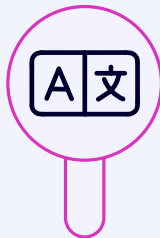
Learner-Centric Needs

Designed to meet the specific psychological and practical needs of the learner.



Disciplinary Integration

Makes use of the underlying methodology and activities of the discipline it serves.



Targeted Linguistics

Centered exclusively on the language-grammar, lexis, register, and genre-appropriate to those specific activities.

English for Academic Purposes (EAP)

EAP is concerned with the communication skills in English required for study purposes in formal education systems.

• Context Universities, and academic language institutes.	• Assessment Focus Critical Thinking & Analysis, Academic Writing, Reading Comprehension
• Skills Emphasized Critical thinking, Communication , Four Language Skills ,Vocabulary and Grammar	• Use of Academic Language correct vocabulary, grammar...

English for Occupational Purposes (EOP)

EOP focuses on the language needed for specific jobs and the immediate linguistic demands of the workplace.



Context

Universities, research centers,
Employee training programs,
and vocational schools.



Skills Emphasized

Industry-specific vocabulary,
meeting communication, report
writing, and workplace protocols.
Academic writing, note-taking,
and critical analysis.



Assessment Focus

Exams, research papers, and
academic presentations.

Examples in Practice

Pilots learning Aviation English ,healthcare workers learning medical vocabulary, hotel staff learning hospitality, office employees learning business English.

3. Learner Obstacles in English Language Learning



Linguistic Difficulties



Core Challenges

Challenges in pronunciation, grammar, and vocabulary



Pronunciation Issues

English sounds may not exist in the learner's first language



Grammar Differences

Grammatical structures may differ from the native language



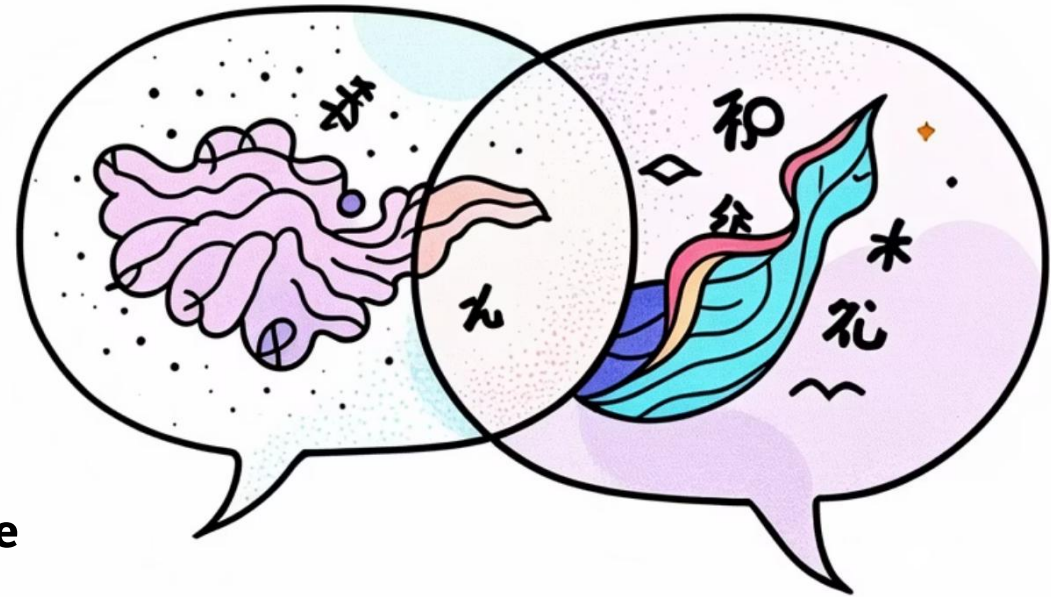
Vocabulary Limitations

Limited vocabulary makes expressing ideas difficult

First Language Interference

The influence of the learner's **first language** on English learning

- **Learners often rely on familiar language patterns**
- **Direct translation may produce incorrect or unnatural sentences**
- **Repeated errors may reduce learners' confidence**

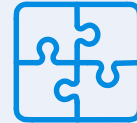


Cognitive Factors



Required Mental Processes

Language learning requires memory, attention, and processing



Simultaneous Management

Learners must manage vocabulary, grammar, and meaning simultaneously



Cognitive Overload

Too much new information may cause cognitive overload



Forgetting

Limited practice may lead to forgetting learned material

Affective Factors

Emotional barriers significantly impact language acquisition and classroom engagement.

1

Emotional Influence

Emotional factors serve as the foundation for the entire language learning experience.

2

Speaking Anxiety

Learners often experience heightened anxiety when speaking English in high-pressure settings.

3

Fear of Mistakes

An overwhelming fear of making mistakes frequently stifles participation and interaction.

4

Confidence Issues

Low self-confidence creates a major barrier that limits essential communication practice.

Learner Motivation and Learning Styles



Learner Motivation	Learning Styles and Preferences
Motivation strongly affects engagement in learning	Learners process information in different way
• Intrinsic motivation: personal interest in learning English • Extrinsic motivation: exams, academic goals, or careers	• Some prefer visual materials (images, diagrams, texts) • Others benefit from listening, discussions, or interaction
Low motivation may lead to passive classroom participation	Learning preferences influence engagement and understanding



4. Teacher and Instructional Obstacles

Teacher-Centered Instruction



Teacher dominates classroom talk and controls the lesson



Students mainly listen and take notes



Limited opportunities for **active participation**



May reduce learners' motivation and confidence

Poor Sequencing of Lessons



Lessons lack a **clear and logical progression**



Activities presented without a coherent flow



Students may feel confused about how ideas are related



Weak connections between lesson stages



Lack of Variety in Classroom Activities



Limited pair work, group work, or interactive tasks



Overreliance on a single type of activity



Learners may lose interest and motivation



Classroom routines become repetitive

Lack of Scaffolding

Tasks presented without sufficient guidance or support

Complex concepts not broken into smaller steps

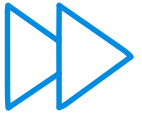
Lack of modeling or guided practice

Learners may struggle to complete activities

Mixed-Ability Classrooms



Students have different proficiency levels



Some learners progress faster than others



Lessons designed for the average level may not meet all needs



Faster learners may become bored while others feel lost

Poor Error Correction



Errors ignored or not addressed effectively



Feedback may be unclear or delayed



Harsh correction may reduce learner confidence



May discourage participation in classroom communication

5. Textbook, Classroom, and Systemic Obstacles



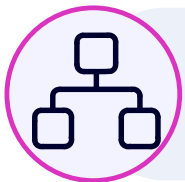
Thinking in the Mother Tongue



Learners often think first in **Arabic or Darija**



Sentences are formed in the mother tongue and then translated into English



Word-by-word translation may produce incorrect structures



This habit slows down spontaneous communication

Differences in Students' Levels



- Students often have **different backgrounds and abilities** in English
- Some learners have basic knowledge, while others are beginners
- These differences make teaching and learning more challenging
- Teachers must address multiple proficiency levels in the same class

Teaching Methods and Low-Level Learners

Some methods are difficult for beginners

The **Communicative Approach** requires frequent speaking and interaction

Low-level students may lack sufficient vocabulary and grammar

Learners may feel anxious or afraid of making mistakes

Challenges with the English Spotlight Textbooks



The **English Spotlight series** was introduced in 2024



Designed to modernize English teaching in Moroccan secondary schools



However, several challenges appear during classroom implementation

Textbook and Curriculum Pressure



Teachers feel pressure to **finish all textbook units** during the school year



Lessons may be rushed to respect the official syllabus



Some students, especially weaker ones, may fall behind



Teaching may become more mechanical and less learner-centered

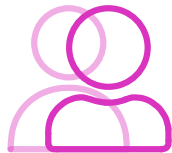
Structural and Resource Constraints



Some textbook contexts may feel **culturally distant** from students



Large classes with **40 or more students** are common



Pair work and communicative activities become difficult to manage



Overcrowded classrooms reduce opportunities for effective interaction

Conclusion

In conclusion, learning English is influenced by several factors related to learners, teaching practices, and educational contexts. Understanding these obstacles can help teachers adopt more effective strategies and create better learning environments. By addressing these challenges, it becomes possible to support learners more effectively and improve the overall process of English language learning.

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